"Kanye Rant" (Can't Handle This)

A Companion Guide

The closing number of Bo Burnham: Make Happy (Netflix, 2016)
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Quick Take

The "Kanye Rant," officially titled "Can't Handle This," is the ten-minute closer of Bo Burnham's 2016 Netflix special Make Happy, and it is widely remembered as one of the great comedy special endings of its era. On the surface it is a pitch-perfect parody of Kanye West's auto-tuned, stream-of-consciousness concert rants from the 2013 Yeezus tour, with Burnham airing grievances about Pringles cans and overstuffed burritos under arena lighting. Then the floor drops out: the trivial complaints give way to a real confession about panic attacks, the impossibility of pleasing an audience while staying honest, and what performing was doing to him. Make Happy holds a 100 percent score on Rotten Tomatoes and this bit is its thesis statement. It also turned out to be prophecy: Burnham quit live performance after this tour, at age 25, and did not return to the stage for five years. If you have ever wondered where Inside (2021) came from, this is the seed.

The Source: What It Is Parodying

The bit is a direct structural parody of a very specific thing: the speeches Kanye West delivered nearly every night of his 2013 Yeezus tour. After performing "Runaway," West would stop the show for ten to twenty-five minutes and deliver a freewheeling monologue over ambient instrumentals, often through heavy Auto-Tune, touching on Nike, corporate gatekeeping, creativity, and his own genius. West preferred the term "visionary streams of consciousness." Slate found the speeches culturally significant enough that in February 2016, a few months before Make Happy premiered, it published transcriptions of every single one, describing them as part rap freestyle, part Auto-Tuned jazz solo, part TED talk, part stand-up routine, and part sermon.

Burnham borrows that exact form. In the special he sets it up by telling the crowd he saw a Kanye show where Kanye talked about his problems through Auto-Tune, so now Bo is going to talk about his. The musical DNA runs deeper than the rants themselves: the Auto-Tune-as-raw-emotion aesthetic traces to West's 808s & Heartbreak (2008), and the nightly rants literally followed "Runaway," the song whose nine-minute vocoder outro is Kanye's own auto-tuned confessional. That lineage matters, because the form Burnham stole was already built for vulnerability. When his parody pivots from burritos to a genuine cry for help, the machinery does not have to change at all.

Crucially, Burnham has been explicit that the bit is not a takedown. In his June 2016 Reddit AMA he called it "more of a love letter to him than a critique" and elsewhere said the mockery is "done with love," praising that West pours himself into his work. His fuller explanation is telling:

> *"For me, Kanye is a completely coherent version of a famous person. Of course a super famous person should be insane. It's the normal, smiley ones that I think are psychos."*
>
> *Bo Burnham, Reddit AMA, June 2016*

The envy is the point. Burnham is not mocking Kanye's unguarded sincerity; he is borrowing it because he cannot allow himself the same thing, which is exactly what the song ends up confessing.

How the Bit Works

The bait

The rant opens with mock grievances delivered with total arena-scale conviction. His hand does not fit inside a Pringles can, and the solution is obvious: just make it wider, a wider cylinder. A Chipotle-style burrito is overstuffed with lettuce past the structural limits of the tortilla, violating the entire premise of a burrito, which is that all of the ingredients are contained within the confines of the tortilla. The complaints are funny precisely because the staging treats them as revelation: haze, moving lights, a lone figure bathed in shafts of white.

The turn

Midway through, Burnham drops the decoy:

> *"I can sit here and pretend like my biggest problems are Pringle cans and burritos. The truth is, my biggest problem's you."*

From there the song becomes a real-time description of the double bind of performing: he wants to please the audience but wants to stay true to himself, wants to give them the night out they deserve but wants to say what he thinks without caring what they think about it. It builds to the repeated hook, "I don't think that I can handle this right now," and to the bleakest and most-quoted line of the special:

> *"Come and watch the skinny kid with a steadily declining mental health, and laugh as he attempts to give you what he cannot give himself."*

The trivial complaints turn out to be load-bearing. They earn the crowd's laughter so that its sudden withdrawal at the pivot becomes the effect. The inversion is elegant: Kanye's rants applied over-serious grandeur to grievances the world found trivial, and Burnham's parody applies trivial grievances to a grandeur that turns out to be earned.

The thesis line

Near the end, Burnham states the operating principle of his entire career in a single couplet: "But you can tell them anything if you just make it funny, make it rhyme. And if they still don't understand you, then you run it one more time." Comedy as a delivery mechanism for things too honest to say plainly. That line is arguably the thesis of Make Happy, of Inside, and of every special he has made.

The two-part ending

The stage show ends with "Thank you, good night! I hope you're happy" and a blackout. Then the special adds something no live audience saw: a quiet coda filmed in Burnham's guest house, alone at a piano, singing a hushed song called "Are You Happy?" directly to the viewer. The key line turns the question outward: "'Cause you're on your own from here, so are you happy?" He then stands up, leaves the piano behind, and walks out of frame toward the light, apparently at peace.

The two-stage ending, arena catharsis followed by domestic silence, is what elevates the special. It also complicates the sincerity of everything that came before. Burnham said onstage earlier in the show that he is not honest for a second up there, and he cautioned in his AMA that even the serious material is "still a very exaggerated, very concentrated, very dramatized version of a real emotion." Whether the confession is the real Bo or one more performance is the special's central, intended ambiguity. On his intent, he was direct:

> *"I wasn't trying to be dark or heavy, I was just trying to speak honestly about what I was feeling... I just wanted to fill the thing out emotionally. Cause everyone I think feels happy and sad and bored and anxious."*
>
> *Bo Burnham, Reddit AMA, June 2016*

The Confession Was Real

The panic attacks in the song were not a device. Burnham has said they began on stage in 2013, during the tour for his previous special what., reportedly starting on opening night at the Edinburgh Fringe, with another hitting in front of roughly three thousand people in Providence, Rhode Island, complete with tunnel vision and numb hands. In the AMA he explained why he built the bit at all:

> *"After my last special 'what.', I started to have panic attacks while on stage, and it made performing really stressful and terrifying for a little while. And so I wanted to try to find a way to talk about that."*
>
> *Bo Burnham, Reddit AMA, June 2016*

He called it "the bit I'm most proud of because it came from something I was pretty ashamed of and didn't even really want to admit to myself," and said that performing it actually made him feel less anxious, because now the anxiety was part of the show. It had a job.

The song was also advance notice. After the Make Happy tour ended in 2016, Burnham quit live performance entirely, at 25, and did not perform for five years. When he came back it was with Inside (2021), whose song "All Eyes on Me" narrates the whole arc directly: he quit because of the panic attacks, got better, planned a return to live comedy in January 2020, "and then the funniest thing happened." Critics widely read "All Eyes on Me" as the direct sequel to "Can't Handle This," both of them auto-tuned addresses to the audience about what the audience

costs him. It won the Grammy for Best Song Written for Visual Media. In between the two specials, the same period of anxiety produced Eighth Grade (2018), his acclaimed directing debut about a kid performing confidence for an online audience. As Burnham told NPR in 2018, he was having panic attacks backstage at the Wilbur Theatre instead of in a bathroom before a pool party, but the feelings are the same.

Critical Reception

Make Happy was released on Netflix on June 3, 2016 and drew near-universal acclaim. It holds a 100 percent critics score on Rotten Tomatoes with a 91 percent audience score, and an 8.3 on IMDb. It won no major industry awards, which is worth stating plainly: its legacy is critical and cultural, and the trophies came later, when Inside, essentially the feature-length version of this song's confession, swept Emmys and won a Grammy.

- The A.V. Club (John Hugar) graded it A minus, called it one of the best stand-up specials of the year, and wrote that Burnham "has grown up, and the results are stunning," noting the special gets more avant-garde and considerably darker than his earlier work.
- Forbes called it easily the best comedy special Netflix had ever produced.
- Decider (Sean L. McCarthy) praised Burnham's "propensity for deconstructing the very nature of entertainment, and the relationship between performer and audience," the exact territory the closer makes explicit.
- Chortle (Steve Bennett) called Burnham "intensively creative" and the show an hour of happiness.
- The Guardian praised the misdirection while dinging some of the raunchier material.

Critics singled out the finale's sincerity specifically, with one reception summary noting it is hard to imagine any other comedian being so sincere. The consensus critical reading matches Burnham's stated intent: the parody is the vehicle, the confession is the cargo.

What You Might Not Know

- The co-director went on to create The Bear. Make Happy was co-directed by Burnham and Christopher Storer, with Andrew Wehde as director of photography. Storer later produced Hasan Minhaj's Homecoming King, produced Eighth Grade, directed episodes of Ramy, and created The Bear (2022), taking Wehde with him. The cinematic house style of prestige stand-up filming largely starts here.
- The lighting is a studied Kanye recreation, not generic parody. Storer said they wanted to blow the ending out and make it look enormous, working with lighting designer Marc Janowitz to match the Yeezus tour's visual language. At the crescendo the lights hit Bo to make him look, in Storer's words, regal, almost religious, the way Kanye would film himself, capturing "this iconic moment of this comedian trapped in his own thoughts."

- The audience was deliberately shot to look alienating. Instead of standard laughing reaction shots, Storer filmed spectators deadpan and staring, almost scary, from the comedian's point of view. The crowd is the antagonist of the song, and the camera treats it that way.
- Burnham wrote it by looping Kanye's "Runaway" instrumental and saying nonsense over it, running his voice through a TC Helicon pedal for the live Auto-Tune. The rant topics were improvised on tour and hardened into the Pringles and burrito text over months; fan-shot video of the bit exists from Indianapolis in March 2015, more than eight months before the December 11, 2015 taping at the Capitol Theatre in Port Chester, New York.
- There is no official Make Happy soundtrack. Burnham said Netflix rights created "a bunch of weird legal stuff" and that he felt the show should be watched and heard together. The one track he uploaded to his own YouTube channel is "Can't Handle This (Kanye Rant)," where it has become one of his most-viewed videos.
- Kanye's most infamous rant came after the parody. The Sacramento "Wicked" rant happened in November 2016, five months after Make Happy premiered, so it reads today like life imitating the bit. There is no record of Kanye ever publicly responding to the song.

Cultural Context

"Can't Handle This" is now treated as an early landmark of the confessional turn in stand-up, the wave of specials that push comedy into open sincerity about mental health and the performer-audience relationship. Make Happy predates Hannah Gadsby's Nanette by two years, and Jerrod Carmichael's Rothaniel by six. Within Burnham's own body of work it is the hinge: the YouTube prodigy who started posting songs from his bedroom at 16 became, in this number, the first comic of his generation to say out loud what an audience costs the person on stage, then spent the next five years off stage proving he meant it.

The defining fan debate is whether the sincerity turn is real. Some first-time viewers found the whiplash unearned; the dominant view after Inside and Burnham's disclosures about his panic attacks is that the rant was genuinely autobiographical, and plenty of fans report that Make Happy makes far more sense on rewatch. A persistent counter-reading holds that the special deliberately makes the question unanswerable, since Burnham tells you mid-show that he is never honest up there, and even the peaceful walk into the yard may be one more performance. The metaphors themselves have taken on a life of their own: Tumblr threads map the Pringles can onto inadequacy, sensory overwhelm, and other experiences of distress that only come out sideways. That is the sign of a bit that outgrew its runtime; people use it as a vocabulary.

If You Liked This

- Bo Burnham: Inside (2021, Netflix). The essential companion. "All Eyes on Me" is the direct sequel to "Can't Handle This," and the whole special lives in the guest-house register the Make Happy epilogue introduced.

- Bo Burnham: what. (2013, free on YouTube). The pre-sincerity version of the same performer, pure artifice and precision, useful contrast for how far Make Happy travels.
- James Acaster: Cold Lasagne Hate Myself 1999 (2020, Vimeo). The strongest non-Burnham comparison, and critics make it by name: a comic who needs the audience's validation, hates needing it, and drops the persona mid-show to talk about the worst year of his life.
- Neal Brennan: 3 Mics (2017, Netflix). Literalizes the comedy-to-confession pivot with a dedicated microphone for soul-baring material about depression.
- Hannah Gadsby: Nanette (2018) and Jerrod Carmichael: Rothaniel (2022). The confessional-turn specials that made this mode mainstream, both downstream of what Make Happy did first.

Companion listening and reading

- Good One: A Podcast About Jokes, "Bo Burnham's Can't Handle This" (Vulture, 2018, rerun 2021). Burnham dissects this exact bit for an hour, live at Vulture Festival. The single best primary source on the song.
- Slate's February 2016 transcription of every Kanye Yeezus tour rant. The parody's source text, published months before the special dropped.
- Kanye West, "Runaway" (My Beautiful Dark Twisted Fantasy) and 808s & Heartbreak. The musical DNA: the looped instrumental Burnham wrote over and the album that made Auto-Tune an instrument of grief.
- WTF with Marc Maron, Bo Burnham episodes (2012 and 2018). The 2018 episode covers quitting live performance after the panic attacks.
- Dissect podcast, season on Inside (2022). Seven episodes of song-by-song analysis, from the show that made its name dissecting Kanye's My Beautiful Dark Twisted Fantasy. The same analysts covered the parodist and the parodied.

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